

Dutch and generally had the better of naval combat in the Baltic during the 17th century.

RUSSIAN ASCENDANCY

The rise of Russia under Tsar Peter the Great fundamentally altered the power balance in the Baltic. The Great Northern War in the first two decades of the 18th century brought victories not only for Russian armies but also for the newly created Russian navy at the battles of Ezel and Grengam. Peter's absolute power in Russia enabled him to build fleets and naval facilities in the Baltic and Black sea. The lack of a Russian seafaring tradition was more difficult to overcome. For many decades the officers of the Russian navy were recruited abroad. Like the Swedes, the Russians maintained two separate forces in the Baltic, a conventional sailing ship fleet for open waters and a fleet of galleys and prams—flat-bottomed ships carrying a heavy gun—to serve in coastal waters.



Backstaff
The backstaff, or English quadrant, was one of the main instruments of navigation until the development of the octant in the 1730s.



SWEDEN'S LAST THROW

Russia replaced Sweden as the major power in the Baltic after the Great Northern War, but through the 18th century Sweden put substantial effort into upgrading its navy, especially the coastal fleet. The traditional galley and prams were augmented by varieties of gun sloop and coastal frigate—udemas, turumas, and hemmemas—the largest capable of mounting up to 48 guns. Sailing ships designed to be rowed when necessary, these innovative British-designed vessels performed well when Sweden went to war with Russia again in 1788–90. There were large-scale battles, ending with the mighty but indecisive encounter known as Second Svensksund. It was Sweden's most impressive naval performance, but the size and population of Russia inevitably meant it would dominate the Baltic in the future.

1672–1725

PETER THE GREAT

LIEUTENANT-ADMIRAL OF THE UNITED PROVINCES

Tsar Peter the Great was the ruler who turned Russia into a major military power. An absolute monarch and ruthless modernizer, he looked to western Europe for examples to follow and for expertise to import. Peter created the Russian navy out of nothing. Fascinated by boats from an early age, he traveled to the Netherlands and England in the 1690s to study shipbuilding and navigation. He worked at the East India Company shipyard in Amsterdam and at the Royal Dockyard in London to gain personal experience of maritime technology. He took back with him shipwrights, experienced seamen, and designs for ships. Peter's conquests on land gave Russia access to the Black Sea and the Baltic, where he founded the city of St Petersburg in 1703 with the naval base of Kronstadt alongside. By the time of his death in 1725 the Russian navy had 48 ships of the line and some 800 galleys.



Peter the Great
Emperor Peter I was physically imposing, loud, violent, and a keen learner. He transformed Russia into a modern European state.